

CONSULTANT CLIENT OPS

The Freelance Pricing & Proposal Cheatsheet

A free reference from Consultant Client Ops

consultant-client-ops.netlify.app

The Freelance Pricing & Proposal Cheatsheet

A one-page-per-topic reference from Consultant Client Ops. Free — no strings.

1. Set a day rate you can defend

Most freelancers guess their rate or copy a competitor. Do this instead:

Day rate = (annual income target + annual overhead) ÷ realistic billable days

- **Billable days:** a year has ~260 working days. After sales, admin, learning, and time off, most solo freelancers realistically bill **100–140 days**, not 220. Be honest here — this is where the number goes wrong.
- **Overhead:** software, insurance, self-employment tax burden, equipment. Budget more than a salaried employee would.
- **Quote projects, not hours:** estimated days × day rate × a 10–25% margin for risk. Present it as one project investment, never "hours × rate" — that invites a negotiation about your time instead of your outcome.

Run your own number free: consultant-client-ops.netlify.app/tools/freelance-day-rate-calculator

2. The 7-section proposal that gets signed

1. **Situation** — the client's problem in their words, 2–3 sentences.
2. **Approach** — 3–5 specific bullets on **how** you'll solve it.
3. **Deliverables** — concrete, nameable artifacts.
4. **Timeline** — phase / deliverable / date.
5. **Investment** — one project price + payment terms attached.
6. **What's not included** — the section that prevents the most scope creep.
7. **Next step** — one action, one deadline.

Send it within 24 hours of the sales call. Follow up on day 3 and day 7 — most "silent" proposals are just deprioritized, not rejected.

3. Stop scope creep before it starts

Scope creep is a documentation problem, not a client problem. Three lines in your scope of work prevent most of it:

- **Itemized deliverables** — specific enough that both sides could check each one off.
- **Explicitly out of scope** — a short list of what you're **not** doing.
- **A revision limit** — a number (commonly 2), and what happens beyond it.

When a new request lands, don't say an awkward no or a silent unpaid yes. Send a **same-day change order**: "Happy to add that — here's what it adds to timeline and cost." A same-day change order reads as professionalism; one sent after the work reads as a surprise bill.

4. Get paid on time

Late payment is usually an invoicing problem, not a client problem:

- **Itemize** every line (match your scope-of-work wording) — vague "consulting services" invoices get stuck in accounts payable.
 - **Ask for a PO number** during onboarding if the client needs one.
 - **State a late fee** on every invoice (commonly 1.5–2%/month) — its presence alone improves on-time payment.
 - **Invoice the same day** a milestone is approved, not at month-end.
-

5. The four weekly habits that end feast-or-famine

1. **Price** every inquiry from a real day rate + tiered rate card.
 2. **Propose** within 24 hours, follow up on a schedule.
 3. **Scope** every job with an itemized SOW + same-day change orders.
 4. **Prospect** on a fixed weekly cadence — outreach, visible expertise, referral asks — regardless of how busy you are.
-

Want the fill-in-the-blank versions of every document above — proposal, contract, scope of work, invoice, change order, retainer, and more? That's the Consultant Client Ops Kit (20 documents, one-time \$39) at consultant-client-ops.netlify.app.

Consultant Client Ops — consultant-client-ops.netlify.app — provided as a starting-point document, not legal advice.